

Korea Daily Brief

Saturday, September 12, 2026

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RE: DPRK fires multiple SRBMs from Wonsan · Hormuz deployment protests · Sado forced labor standoff · Arctic route milestone

KOSPI
6,909.91
▼ -1.8%

USD/KRW
1,341.05
▼ -0.5%

BRENT
\$104.61
▼ -2.8%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 North Korea fired multiple short-range ballistic missiles from near Wonsan toward the East Sea at 5:20 a.m. KST, flying approximately 250 km — the launch came days after the DPRK founding anniversary and one year to the day after a similar SRBM volley on Sep 12, 2024.
- 2 Approximately 2,000 civilians marched through central Seoul to oppose any Hormuz Strait deployment, chanting 'Refuse Hormuz deployment' and marching to the presidential residence, as anti-deployment protests also convened in Daejeon and other cities.
- 3 Japan held the Sado mine memorial for the third consecutive year without acknowledging forced labor, and South Korea boycotted for the third consecutive year, leaving the bilateral history dispute structurally unresolved.

• TOP STORIES

DPRK

North Korea fires multiple short-range ballistic missiles toward East Sea from Wonsan

North Korea launched several short-range ballistic missiles from near Wonsan starting at 5:20 a.m. KST Saturday, flying approximately 250 km before landing in the East Sea, according to the ROK Joint Chiefs of Staff. USFK and INDOPACOM confirmed awareness of the launch and said they assessed no immediate threat, reaffirming alliance defense commitments. The AP reported the launch followed a joint ROK-US military drill that Pyongyang characterized as a provocation — the CSIS database records an identical SRBM volley from Wonsan on Sep 12, 2024.

NK News · Reuters · AP · Bloomberg · Yonhap

US-KOREA

Approximately 2,000 march in Seoul against Hormuz Strait deployment; rallies held nationwide

Civil society groups including Chamyeo Yondae and Jaju Tongil Pyeonghwa Yondae assembled at Jongno, Seoul on Saturday afternoon, marching to the presidential residence chanting 'Refuse Hormuz deployment — do not cooperate with a war of aggression.' Anti-deployment rallies also convened in Daejeon, with organizers framing troop dispatch as entry into a Trump-initiated war. The demonstration follows Foreign Minister **Cho Hyun**'s statement to Iran on Sep 11 that no deployment decision has been made, and the return of an ROK assessment team from the UAE on Sep 10.

한겨레 · 경향신문 (Sep 12)

JAPAN-KOREA

Japan holds Sado mine memorial without acknowledging forced labor for third consecutive year; South Korea boycotts for third year

Japan's government representative at the Sep 12 Sado island gold mine memorial — Foreign Ministry official Hamamoto Yukiya — stated that Korean Peninsula workers 'labored under dangerous and harsh conditions,' using language virtually identical to prior years, without acknowledging the coercive nature of the labor. South Korea's government boycotted for the third consecutive year, having failed to reach agreement with Tokyo on the wording of the memorial's acknowledgment. Japan registered Sado as a UNESCO World Cultural Heritage site in 2024 with a commitment to hold annual memorial events.

Yonhap EN · 뉴시스 · 동아일보 · 경향신문 (Sep 12)

• OVERNIGHT

- DPRK

US military confirms awareness of DPRK launch, reaffirms defense commitment to ROK and Japan · Yonhap English

INDOPACOM statement issued.
- DPRK

DPRK fired missiles after ROK-US military drill it characterized as provocation · Washington Post / AP

AP framing links launch to exercise.
- ENERGY

Lee says oil supply stable; Middle East crude dependency cut from 70% to 50s% in months · 한겨레

Strategic reserve swap in place.
- ENERGY

Bab el-Mandeb blocked alongside Hormuz — dual oil route siege becomes reality · SBS

Double blockade pressures Seoul energy security.
- ENERGY

Korean domestic gas prices fall for 17th straight week despite rising global crude · SBS

Rising global costs expected to pass through later this month.
- DPRK

NK Pro: Kim Jong Un dominated founding anniversary state media; US criticism notably muted · NK Pro

Pyongyangites mobilized for state events all week.

• STAT OF THE DAY

250 km

Flight distance of DPRK SRBMs fired toward East Sea, Sep 12

The missiles were detected at 5:20 a.m. KST, launched from the Wonsan area; ROK-US joint analysis is ongoing on exact specifications.

ROK JCS via Yonhap / NK News / MND spokesperson

PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

KIM JONG UN

WATCH FLAG

● **No appearance (4d since last)**

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

1. North Korea's Kim thanks troops on overseas operations on founding anniversary **KIM**

Kim Jong Un publicly thanked DPRK troops deployed in overseas military operations in a founding anniversary statement — the first official KCNA acknowledgment of overseas military deployments. — KCNA (Reuters)

2. Russia slams UN watchdog for reporting on North Korean nuclear facility

Russia dismissed the IAEA's report on the new Yongbyon uranium enrichment facility at a Vienna session, citing lack of access — backing Pyongyang's rejection of international inspections. — KCNA (NK News)

3. Kim Jong Un wants North Koreans to have more (state-sanctioned) fun **KIM**

KCNA reported Kim issued guidance encouraging expansion of state-sanctioned recreational activities for citizens — part of the founding anniversary domestic messaging cycle. — KCNA (Reuters)

Bottom line: KCNA's founding anniversary output confirmed overseas troop deployment — a historic first — and Kim has been absent from state media for 4 days since the Sep 8 Kang Kon commissioning; the post-anniversary window and today's SRBM launch together sustain elevated watch status on Punggye-ri.

● **ROK GOVERNMENT**

President + Ministries · Saturday, September 12, 2026

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Presidential Office condemns DPRK missile launch as UNSC violation

President Lee Jae-myung

The presidential Office of National Security issued a statement Saturday denouncing North Korea's multiple SRBM launches as a violation of UN Security Council resolutions. The office called on Pyongyang to halt provocation.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

국방부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

JCS detects multiple DPRK SRBMs launched from Wonsan toward East Sea

MND Spokesperson

The Joint Chiefs of Staff reported that North Korea fired multiple short-range ballistic missiles starting at 5:20 a.m. KST from near Wonsan on the east coast; the missiles flew approximately 250 km. ROK-US intelligence authorities tracked the launches from the outset and shared information with Japan.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Lee reassures public on oil prices, cuts Middle East import dependency from 70% to 50%

President Lee Jae-myung

President **Lee Jae-myung** posted on X that crude oil import diversification and long-distance freight subsidies have reduced Middle East dependence from 70% to the 50s within months. He stated domestic refined product prices remain stable under a maximum price regime and export volume controls.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Kang Shin-chul **NOMINATED**

Minister of National Defense (nominee)

Defense Minister nominee Kang Shin-chul testified at the National Assembly that OPCON transfer should proceed under a 'no added conditions' principle, signaling the Lee administration's intended approach to alliance management. Confirmation hearings are ongoing.

Kim Seung-won **NOMINATED**

Minister of Justice (nominee)

Justice Minister nominee Kim Seung-won submitted written answers to the National Assembly affirming prosecutorial neutrality on President Lee's pending criminal cases and reconfirming his position that prosecutors' independent investigative powers should be fully abolished.

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Rival parties clash over Supreme Court Chief Justice's authority to re-nominate sitting Supreme Court candidates

Judiciary Committee / National Assembly floor

Democratic Party demanded Chief Justice Cho Hee-dae re-submit nominations from the existing candidate recommendation committee immediately, while PPP called the Blue House pressure on the Supreme Court's appointment powers an 'overreach.' Two Supreme Court seats remain vacant, one for more than six months.

Justice Minister nominee Kim Seung-won submits written answers affirming prosecutorial neutrality on President Lee's pending criminal cases

Judiciary Committee (confirmation hearing preparation)

Nominee **Kim Seung-won** told PPP lawmaker Ju Jin-woo in a written response that he would 'strictly supervise and manage' prosecution to maintain political neutrality and would separate his past legislative role from ministerial duties; he also reaffirmed full abolition of prosecutors' independent investigative powers.

• **US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT**

Steel and aluminium remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff in force. Section 301 investigations launched March 11 against South Korea and 15 other partners are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

WATCH THIS DATE

next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES

Steel & Aluminum	SECTION 232	50%
Copper	SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts	SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives	SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)	25%
Pharmaceuticals	SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION	0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST	0%

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

• **BUSINESS & ECONOMY**

MACRO · 한겨레

Government deploys record 149 billion won in subsidies to halve Chuseok beef and fruit prices

The Ministry of Agriculture, Food and Rural Affairs expanded the 2026 Chuseok discount support budget roughly three times to 149 billion won compared to last year, running discount sales on Korean beef (up to 50% off), pork, and produce through Sep 30 at Nonghyup Hanaro Mart and major retailers. The move directly responds to inflation anxiety ahead of the Sep 25-30 Chuseok holiday period.

MANUFACTURING · 한겨레 / YONHAP

South Korea's Panstar Acro completes first commercial Arctic route voyage to UK in 21 days

The container ship Panstar Acro arrived at Felixstowe, UK on Sep 12, cutting approximately 10 days off the traditional Suez Canal route. The Ministry of Oceans and Fisheries said the government subsidized long-distance freight costs to make the route viable; a return to Busan is expected next month.

Panstar

MANUFACTURING · FEDERAL REGISTER

US Commerce Department publishes preliminary antidumping duty results for Korean brass rod (2023-2025)

The Federal Register published preliminary results of an antidumping duty administrative review covering South Korean brass rod exports for the 2023-2025 period, affecting Korean metal exporters and US industrial buyers.

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

38%

▼ 2 pts vs Sep 4

Gallup Korea · week of 2026-09-11

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 38% across 3 readings

RULING
Democratic

39%

OPPOSITION
People Power

25%

INDEPENDENTS

26%

Gallup Korea Spotlight August 25-27, 2026

Security Policy and Presidential Approval: Lee Jae-myung's approval stood at 42% in the Aug 25-27 Gallup poll (lowest since inauguration), with disapproval first crossing 50%; the poll covered OPCON transfer, denuclearization, inter-Korean military balance, and proposed military academy merger.

Discourse: Anti-Hormuz deployment protests drew approximately 2,000 marchers through central Seoul on Sep 12, with parallel rallies in Daejeon; organizers framed deployment as participation in a US-initiated war; protesters marched to the US Embassy before proceeding to the presidential residence.

• UPCOMING

Oct
1

ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance

statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct
3

National Foundation Day (개천절)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9

Hangul Day (한글날)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10

Workers' Party founding day

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

• THE WIRE

US-KOREA

WASHINGTON POST

Yoon acquitted in case related to South Korean marine's drowning

A South Korean court acquitted former President **Yoon Suk-yeol** in a case related to a marine's drowning, the Washington Post reported, describing it as a rare legal reprieve. This follows his earlier acquittal in a power abuse case over an envoy appointment (reported Sep 11).

TECHNOLOGY

FINANCIAL TIMES

South Korea arms itself to protect chip secrets from foreign spies

South Korea has strengthened laws and enforcement mechanisms to prevent theft of semiconductor intellectual property by foreign intelligence services, the FT reported. The Bloomberg story from Sep 11 on the spy law for chip secrets provides corroborating detail on the legislative push.

DPRK

뉴스스

North Korea using Iranian and other third-country nationals as interview proxies to infiltrate US firms with IT workers

NBC News, cited by Newsis, reports that DPRK IT organizations have recruited Iranian, Syrian, Lebanese, and South African nationals to appear in video interviews on behalf of North Korean workers seeking employment at US firms; at least 14 Iranians were directly recruited since 2024, with at least 2 passing interviews and receiving job offers. Proxy interviewees were offered \$500/month paid in cryptocurrency.

• ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

President Lee Jae-myung @Jaemyung_Lee

“Busan Mayor Jeon Jae-su and the citizens of Busan: I support the dream of Busan as a maritime capital and the full-scale development of the Arctic route. As promised, I will strongly advance the Arctic route era and accelerate Busan's designation as a maritime capital.”

Context: Posted in response to the Panstar Acro docking at Felixstowe, UK — South Korea's first commercial Arctic route container voyage, completing the journey in 21 days from Busan (departed Aug 22).

[View on X →](#)

MND Spokesperson @MNDSpokesperson

“Our military detected multiple short-range ballistic missiles fired from the Wonsan area toward the East Sea starting at approximately 05:20 on September 12. The detected missiles flew approximately 250 km; ROK-US intelligence is conducting precise analysis of specifications. ROK-US intelligence authorities have tracked and shared related trends from the outset, and missile information has also been shared with Japan.”

Context: The JCS statement constitutes the primary official public disclosure of the Sep 12 SRBM launch; USFK and INDOPACOM subsequently issued their own confirmatory statements reaffirming alliance defense commitments.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Lee Jae-myung
ROK President

“I have never abandoned the goals and values of reform for a single moment. The biggest obstacle to reform is those who obstruct reform in the name of reform.”

Analyst: The statement, posted on X Sep 12 citing commentary by Park Tae-hun of the Youth Today Institute, comes as the President's approval rating fell to 38% (Gallup Korea, week of Sep 11) and Democratic Party ally Yong Hye-in faces ministerial controversy.

[Source →](#)



Cho Hyun
ROK Foreign Minister

“No decision has been made on a possible Hormuz deployment.”

Analyst: Statement was delivered during ministerial-level talks with Iran on Sep 11, directly addressing Tehran's concern about a Seoul military presence in the strait; the ROK assessment team returned from the UAE on Sep 10.

[Source →](#)

COMMENTARY

THE DIPLOMAT

What Role Does Denuclearization Have in North Korea-US Dialogue Today?

The piece breaks down how both Washington and Pyongyang have repositioned their stated denuclearization postures, with the US less insistent on CVID as a precondition and the DPRK framing its nuclear program as a permanent sovereign right. The author maps the resulting conceptual gap that any resumed dialogue would have to bridge.

RESEARCH

CITY JOURNAL B

The Growing Army of North Korea Apologists in America

The piece argues that a growing segment of American academics, former officials, and commentators have adopted positions that excuse or rationalize DPRK behavior in ways that undermine sanctions enforcement and alliance cohesion. It identifies specific argumentative patterns — attributing DPRK nuclear development to US 'provocation,' downplaying human rights abuses — and traces their policy influence. The author contends this intellectual environment weakens the bipartisan consensus undergirding the US-ROK alliance.

Implication: Relevant to ongoing internal US debates over the terms for any Trump-Kim diplomacy and to the Lee administration's calculus on how much diplomatic space Washington will extend.

[Read →](#)

• SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.

imagery as of 2026-09-10

ALERT ▲

Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind.

imagery as of 2026-09-08

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

Sep 11, 2026: 38 North satellite imagery analysis shows the new North Korea-China border crossing (new Yalu River Bridge) appears close to opening. Mar 12, 2026: Cross-border passenger train service resumed between Sinuiju and Dandong after COVID-era suspension.

imagery as of 2026-09-11

ACTIVITY ▲

Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail.

imagery as of 2026-09-08

7 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-05.

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